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For the President
23 September 2026

Today's Brief

UN-GENERAL ASSEMBLY: Trump presses Iran and a sovereignty agenda as allies break openly over Gaza.

ARCTIC: US locks in long-term military access to Greenland in a security pact with Denmark.

IRAN: Kushner-Witkoff channel reopens with Tehran as new US aviation sanctions bite.

UKRAINE-RUSSIA: Zelensky-Trump meeting pushes an energy truce as overnight strikes continue.

NORTH KOREA: Pyongyang touts a 'new-type' weapon after back-to-back missile tests.

GLOBAL ECONOMY: Oil slides below \$100 on easing Gulf-supply fears; US equities set records.

NOTES: UK settlement sanctions, a synagogue attack in Canada, and Gaza-ceasefire strains.

For the President
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At UN Debate, Trump Presses Iran and a Sovereignty Agenda as Allies Split Openly Over Gaza

We assess that the opening day of the 81st UN General Assembly on 22 September hardened, rather than narrowed, the divide between Washington and several close partners over the Middle East, even as the President used the rostrum to project strength toward Iran. In a roughly 38-minute address, Mr. Trump warned that Iran's leadership faces a choice between "greatness" and "obliteration," defended his handling of global conflicts, said the United States would encourage artificial intelligence rather than "rein" it in, and framed his agenda around national sovereignty and a rejection of "global control." The speech made only a single, glancing reference to Israel and none to Prime Minister Netanyahu — a calibration we judge was deliberate, aimed at preserving room for the Iran track while distancing the President from the sharpest fights over Gaza.

- The split among partners was unusually public. French President Macron called the situation in Gaza "a spectacle that shames us all"; Turkish President Erdogan accused Israel of a "genocidal mindset" and prompted the Israeli delegation to walk out; and Qatar's Emir and Jordan's King Abdullah II added pointed criticism of Israeli conduct in Gaza and Syria.
- We assess this fracture complicates US efforts to keep a broad coalition behind the postwar "Board of Peace" reconstruction framework and to manage recognition momentum for a Palestinian state, which several G7 partners have advanced.
- Most of Iran's delegation walked out during the President's remarks — a signaling move, we judge, rather than a rupture, given that indirect contacts continued on the sidelines the same day (see Iran item).

For Washington, the near-term question is whether the sovereignty-forward message and the Iran ultimatum can coexist with the quieter diplomacy now underway. We expect the administration to lean on bilateral sidelines meetings this week to contain the transatlantic friction on Gaza while testing whether the Iran channel can produce anything concrete.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, INR, DIA, and open sources.

For the President
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US Locks In Long-Term Military Access to Greenland in Arctic Security Pact

We assess that the security agreement the President signed with Denmark and Greenland on 22 September, on the margins of the General Assembly, gives the United States durable, treaty-anchored access to the island and materially strengthens the US position across the North Atlantic and Arctic. The accord provides for permanent US basing rights, authorizes "defense areas" beyond Pituffik at Narsarsuaq in the south and Mestersvig in the east, and permits wide military mobility — including undersea access. It has no end date.

- The agreement bars any US adversary from establishing a base, military presence, or sensitive investment on Greenland without Washington's approval — a provision aimed squarely at Russian and Chinese Arctic ambitions.
- It reaffirms the sovereignty of Greenland and the Kingdom of Denmark; should Greenland become independent, it would remain in NATO and assume Denmark's obligations under the pact.
- We judge the deal caps roughly a year of US–Danish friction over Greenland's status and converts a source of allied strain into a consolidated security gain.

For Washington, the payoff is geographic: expanded access astride the Greenland-Iceland-United Kingdom (GIUK) gap improves undersea-warfare and early-warning posture against Russian submarine and Arctic activity. We expect follow-on questions over pace of construction, cost-sharing, and Greenlandic domestic politics; open-source imagery of the named sites is consistent with existing infrastructure that could be expanded relatively quickly.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from NGA, DIA, INR, and open sources.

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Kushner-Witkoff Channel Reopens With Tehran as US Tightens Aviation Sanctions

We assess that indirect US–Iran diplomacy resumed in earnest on 22 September, when special envoy Steve Witkoff and senior adviser Jared Kushner met Iranian officials for about three hours on the UNGA sidelines; the President later said it "went very well." The contact is the most substantive in months and comes against the backdrop of this year's US–Iran conflict and a fragile pause in Gulf tensions. We judge both sides are probing whether a limited transactional arrangement is possible without either abandoning maximalist public positions.

- Iran conveyed conditions for reopening the Strait of Hormuz to normal traffic: lifting naval blockade measures, releasing frozen assets, and winding down conflict across its "resistance" fronts.
- Even as the channel reopened, new US sanctions targeting Iranian aviation took effect the same day — a deliberate pressure-and-talk sequencing we assess is designed to preserve leverage.
- At the Security Council, the permanent members remain split over whether the "snapback" UN sanctions are legally in force, with Russia and China continuing to contest the mechanism's activation — leaving the multilateral sanctions picture contested.

A decision point comes when the two sides test whether Hormuz de-escalation can be sequenced against phased sanctions relief. We expect continued back-channel contact, but caution that the gap between Tehran's demands and the President's public ultimatum remains wide; the talks could stall quickly if either side judges the other is negotiating in bad faith.

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Zelensky-Trump Meeting Pushes an Energy Truce as Overnight Strikes Continue

We assess that the roughly 40-minute Trump-Zelensky bilateral on 22 September produced fresh momentum toward a narrow, energy-focused ceasefire rather than a comprehensive settlement. President Zelensky said Kyiv is ready for "any format" of an energy-infrastructure truce with Moscow and floated a trilateral meeting with the President and Vladimir Putin; Mr. Trump said Mr. Putin is willing to meet and that peace could come "sooner than people think." Mr. Zelensky said he hopes to end the war before winter.

- The diplomacy unfolded against continued fighting: overnight Russian missile and drone strikes hit at least four Ukrainian regions — with Dnipropetrovsk, Kirovohrad, and Poltava among the main targets — killing at least five people.
- Ukrainian long-range forces struck another Russian oil refinery, extending Kyiv's campaign against Russian energy infrastructure. NGA assessments of commercial satellite imagery are consistent with fresh fire damage at the targeted facility.
- We judge an energy-infrastructure truce is the most plausible near-term deliverable because it is verifiable and serves both sides ahead of winter — but it would not resolve the territorial core of the war.

For Washington, the test is whether Moscow reciprocates or merely uses the diplomacy to buy time. We expect the administration to press for an early, limited energy ceasefire as a confidence-building step, while remaining skeptical that Mr. Putin has decided to end the war on terms Kyiv could accept.

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North Korea Touts 'New-Type' Weapon After Back-to-Back Missile Tests

We assess that Pyongyang is using a compressed testing tempo to advertise progress on advanced strike systems and to signal resolve amid US–South Korean military activity. On 22 September, state media said Kim Jong Un hailed a newly tested "new-type" weapon of "great significance," with released imagery indicating a system Pyongyang has previously described as hypersonic. The announcement followed two short-range ballistic missiles fired within about three hours on 20 September.

- North Korea framed the tests as a response to US–ROK drills it says are driving tensions on the Peninsula — consistent with its standard pattern of pairing capability demonstrations with grievance messaging.
- Mr. Kim again observed a launch alongside his teenage daughter, widely read as continued grooming of a potential successor and an effort to project regime durability.
- We judge the "hypersonic" characterization warrants caution: a genuine, reliable maneuvering-reentry capability would meaningfully stress regional missile defenses, but Pyongyang's claims routinely outrun demonstrated performance.

We expect further tests calibrated to the drill schedule and to diplomatic signaling. What to watch is whether subsequent launches show the sustained maneuvering and range that would substantiate the hypersonic claim, versus a repackaging of existing short-range systems.

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Oil Slides Below \$100 on Easing Gulf-Supply Fears as US Equities Set Records

We assess that markets are pricing in a reduced near-term risk premium on Middle East energy supply. Brent crude settled below \$100 a barrel on 22 September, down roughly 9% over four sessions, after Saudi Arabia restarted a key export pipeline and as renewed US–Iran diplomacy eased fears of a prolonged supply disruption. The move rippled outward: gold traded near \$4,360 an ounce and the Nasdaq Composite closed at a record, lifted by technology shares.

- The oil retreat, if sustained, would ease inflation pressure and dampen expectations of further Federal Reserve rate hikes — a tailwind for equities but a squeeze on high-cost producers.
- We judge the price relief is contingent and reversible: it rests on the Gulf de-escalation and the Iran channel holding, either of which could snap back quickly if the diplomacy fails.
- Elevated gold alongside record equities signals that investors are hedging geopolitical tail-risk even as risk appetite runs high — a posture we assess reflects unresolved uncertainty around Iran and Ukraine.

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Notes

United Kingdom — Israel: London moved to sanction Israeli settlements, drawing attention on the UNGA sidelines; asked about the decision on 22 September, the President said he was unfamiliar with it. We assess the step widens visible daylight between Washington and a close ally on Israel policy.

Canada — Homeland/Antisemitism: A gunman died after opening fire at a synagogue on Yom Kippur, one of several security incidents around the holiday. We judge the episode will sharpen allied concern over threats to Jewish communities; US homeland elements are almost certainly reviewing for any read-across.

Gaza ceasefire — strain: Despite the standing truce, a reported drone strike killed two people in Gaza City's Tuffah neighborhood on 22 September, and Israeli forces detained more than a dozen settlement activists who illegally crossed into Syria. We assess intermittent violations continue to test the ceasefire's durability without yet breaking it.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from INR, FBI, DHS, and open sources.